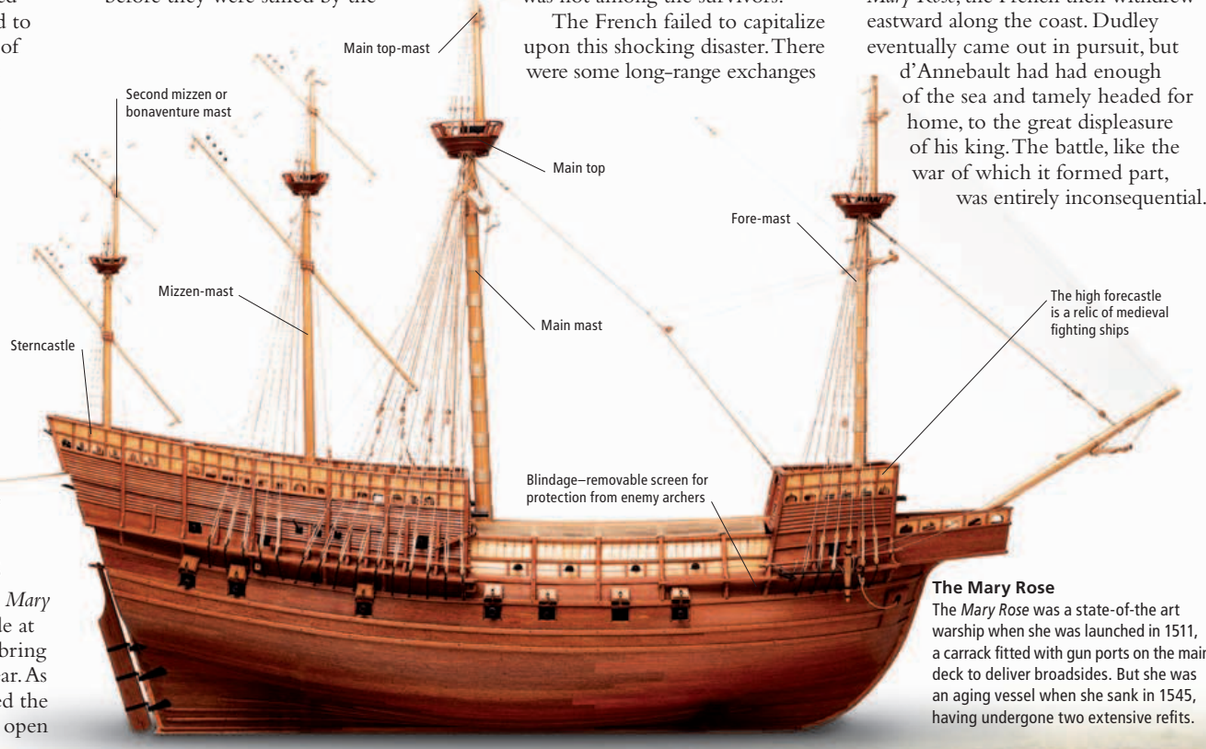
French galleys rowed into the Solent toward Portsmouth. When they were sighted, the king was dining on board the great ship *Henry Grace à Dieu* with various officers, including Sir George Carew, Dudley's newly appointed vice-admiral. The king departed to view events from the ramparts of Southsea Castle, while his fleet prepared to fight.

The English ships had great trouble extricating themselves from their crowded anchorage with barely a breath of wind to aid them. In the afternoon, however, a wind arose and they began to emerge, sailing out toward the French galleys in the Solent. The large but aged carrack *Mary Rose*, with Vice-Admiral Carew on board, took the lead. The vice-admiral's wife Lady Mary Carew was among the spectators alongside King Henry who were watching the action from Southsea Castle.

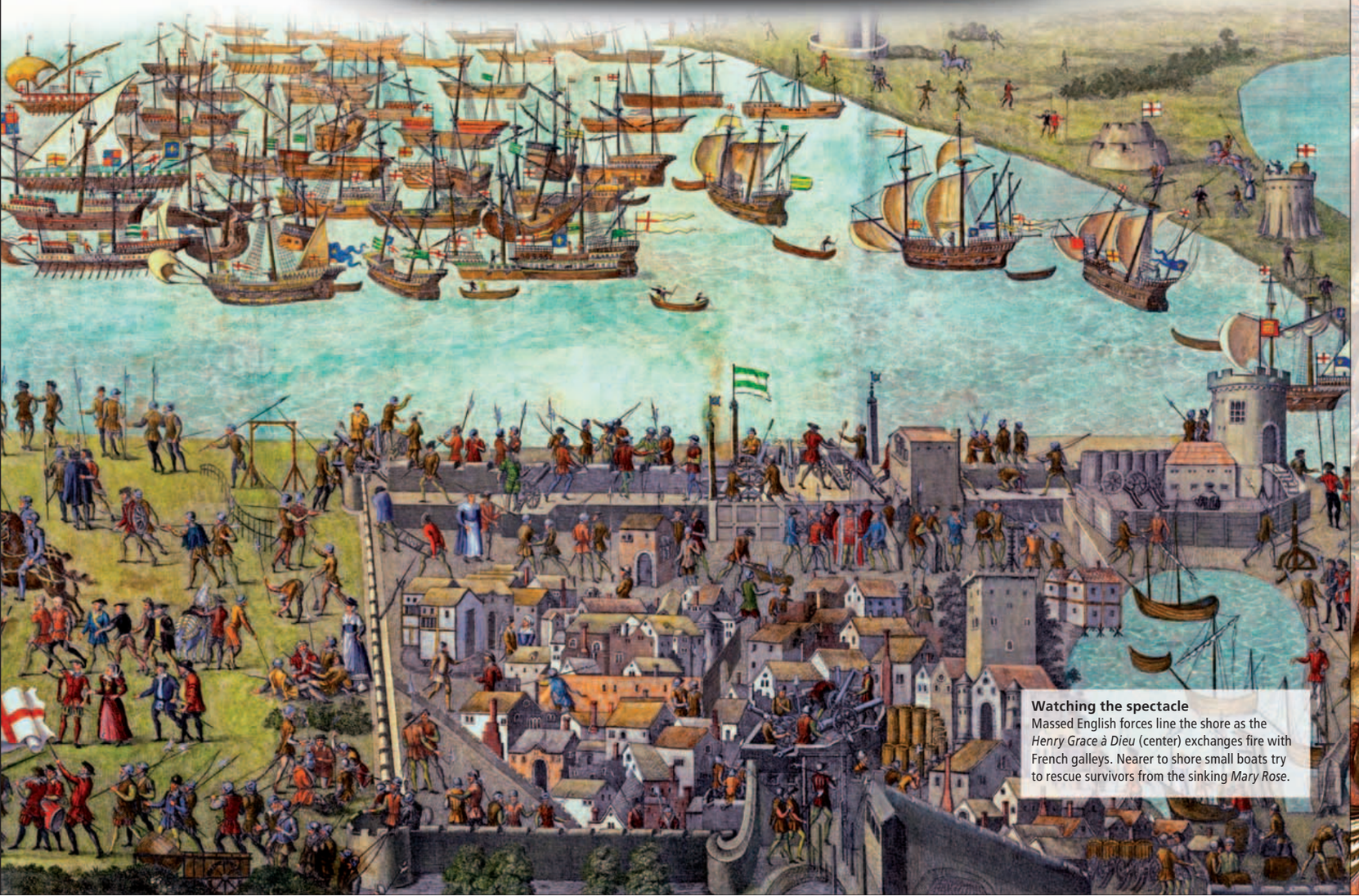
THE MARY ROSE SINKS

Witnesses to the battle saw the *Mary Rose* fire her starboard broadside at the galleys and come about to bring the guns on the port side to bear. As she did so, a gust of wind caused the ship to heel over, plunging her open gun ports below water. The *Mary Rose* sank with awesome swiftness. The cries of the trapped crew were momentarily audible to the onlookers on the castle ramparts, before they were stifled by the waves. Lady Carew fainted, while King Henry cried out in anguish at the sight. All but 30 of the 415 people on board the *Mary Rose* were drowned. Sir George Carew was not among the survivors.

The French failed to capitalize upon this shocking disaster. There were some long-range exchanges of fire between the two fleets the following day and French soldiers briefly went ashore on the Isle of Wight. But while the English vainly attempted to salvage the sunken *Mary Rose*, the French then withdrew eastward along the coast. Dudley eventually came out in pursuit, but d'Annebault had had enough of the sea and tamely headed for home, to the great displeasure of his king. The battle, like the war of which it formed part, was entirely inconsequential.



The Mary Rose
The *Mary Rose* was a state-of-the art warship when she was launched in 1511, a carrack fitted with gun ports on the main deck to deliver broadsides. But she was an aging vessel when she sank in 1545, having undergone two extensive refits.



Watching the spectacle
Massed English forces line the shore as the *Henry Grace à Dieu* (center) exchanges fire with French galleys. Nearer to shore small boats try to rescue survivors from the sinking *Mary Rose*.